

Course

Introduction to Empirical Methods in Political Science

PS 210

Fall 2026

Department of Political Science
Weinberg College of Arts and Sciences

Professor

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312 Scott Hall

Office Hours Mondays 3-5pm

Key Dates and Times

Class meets:

Tuesday and Thursday, 3:30 to 4:50

Harris Hall L07

- Thursday, September 24th: First day of class.
- October 8th: First homework due.
- November 3rd: Midterm.
- November 10th: Second homework due.
- November 25th: Third homework due.
- Friday, December 11th, 12:00-2:00 PM: In-class final exam.

Basic Course Information

This course provides an introduction to the empirical methods political scientists use to answer questions about politics, and the reasons why such methods matter. After exploring how hard it is to make good descriptive and causal inferences about politics, we will examine three basic strategies for overcoming the obstacles to reliable knowledge about the political world: experimentation, large N or quantitative studies (AKA statistics), and small N studies that use qualitative reasoning.

At the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Understand and explain why descriptive and causal inference are difficult tasks in political science.
- Identify possible weaknesses in academic or other descriptive and causal claims about politics.
- Understand and explain the strengths and weaknesses of experimental research designs for causal inference about politics.
- Understand and explain the strengths and weaknesses of survey and regression-based quantitative research designs for descriptive and causal inference about politics.
- Understand and explain the strengths and weaknesses of qualitative methods for descriptive and causal inference about politics.
- Apply all of these tools to critically evaluating examples of political science research.

- Think about how empirical evidence matters to your own questions about politics.

Grades will be based on three homework assignments (30% total), a midterm (30% total), a final exam (30%), and participation (10%). Homework due dates will be set throughout the quarter. Students are encouraged to form study groups and work together but must complete and submit their own homework.

Participation (10%) – Your participation grade has three components:

- Reading Check-Ins (4%): Brief quizzes at the start of several classes to verify you’ve completed the reading. Your two lowest scores will be dropped.
- Weekly “Muddiest Point” Posts (3%): Each Wednesday by 9:00 PM, post one sentence on Canvas identifying something from the week’s materials you found confusing. Full credit for any good-faith submission.
- Engagement (3%): Active, constructive participation in class discussions and group work.

Late work will be accepted but with a grade penalty equivalent to 5% per day. Late exams will not be accepted without prior communication with the instructors or an overriding exemption due to university policy.

Mathematical background. This course introduces statistical concepts at a conceptual level. Students should be comfortable with high-school algebra (e.g., interpreting graphs, understanding equations like $y = a + bx$). No prior statistics or calculus is required.

The textbook for this course, available for free online, is *Empirical Methods in Political Science: An introduction*, edited by Jean Clipperton. That text can be found at the library’s github. The textbook will be supplemented as needed with other readings available electronically.

Research Study Participation Requirement

Students enrolled in this course are required to complete a research participation assignment. This will involve taking part in studies conducted by students and faculty from the Department of Political Science, and will include up to 4 hours of research study participation. This will primarily require completing on-line surveys, and in some cases in-person studies at Scott Hall. Students will be able to see how political science studies are conducted and can request information about the studies at the end of the quarter. Students who prefer not to participate in research may opt for an alternative that entails reading a book chapter about political science research and writing a five page reaction paper. The typical chapter is about 20 pages and thus reading it and writing a five-page paper should take approximately four hours. To select the paper option, email the instructor by October 1st; no justification is required.

Northwestern University Syllabus Standards

This course follows the Northwestern University Syllabus Standards. Students are responsible for familiarizing themselves with this information.

Course Schedule and Readings (Fall 2026)

Week 1

Thu, Sept 24 – Asking social science questions.

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapter 1.

Week 2

Tue, Sept 29 – Data.

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapter 4.

Thu, Oct 1 – Causation.

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapter 2.

Week 3 Tue, Oct 6 – Statistical Computing Lab I: Introduction to R for descriptive statistics and visualization. (*Hands-on lab; bring laptop with R & RStudio installed.*)

Thu, Oct 8 – Causal inference in action.

Reading: Morral, Andrew R., and Rosanna Smart. “Concealed Carry Laws and Violence in America.” *Annual Review of Criminology* 9 (2026). <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-criminol-032924-013352>

Due: First homework.

Week 4

Tue, Oct 13 – Experiments.

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapter 7.

Thu, Oct 15 – Applied experiments.

Readings:

- Gramacho, Wladimir G., and Mathieu Turgeon. “When politics collides with public health: COVID-19 vaccine country of origin and vaccination acceptance in Brazil.” *Vaccine* 39 (2021): 2608–12.
- Bos, L., Schemer, C., Corbu, N., et al. “The effects of populism as a social identity frame on persuasion and mobilisation: Evidence from a 15-country experiment.” *European Journal of Political Research* 59 (2020): 3–24.

Week 5

Tue, Oct 20 – Sampling and survey research.

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapter 6. **Thu, Oct 22 – Foundations of Statistical Inference and Bivariate Regression** (confidence intervals, significance tests, correlation, bivariate regression).

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapters 5 & 8.

Week 6

Tue, Oct 27 – Multivariate regression (conceptual).

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapter 8 (continued). **Thu, Oct 29** – Midterm review.

Week 7

Tue, Nov 3 – **Midterm exam** (in class).

Covers all material from Sept 24 through Oct 27. **Thu, Nov 5** – Statistical Computing Lab II: Introduction to R for basic regression. (*Hands-on lab.*)

Week 8

Tue, Nov 10 – Machine Learning Concepts (Lecture & Demo).

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapter 12.

Due: Second homework. Thu, Nov 12 – The qualitative comparative method.

Reading: Clipperton, ed., Chapter 9.

Week 9

Tue, Nov 17 – Applied Qualitative Methods. *Readings:*

- Gibson, Edward L. “Boundary Control: Subnational Authoritarianism in Democratic Countries.” *World Politics* 58, no. 1 (2005): 101–132. <https://doi.org/10.1353/wp.2006.0018>.
- Thurston, Chloe N. “Policy Feedback in the Public–Private Welfare State: Advocacy Groups and Access to Government Homeownership Programs, 1934–1954.” *Studies in American Political Development* 29, no. 2 (2015): 250–267.
- Gerzso, Thalia. “Judicial Resistance During Electoral Disputes: Evidence from Kenya.” *Electoral Studies* 85 (2023). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.electstud.2023.102653>.

Thu, Nov 19 – Applied text methods, LLMs, and AI in social science. *Reading:* Rossiter, Erin L. “Measuring Agenda Setting in Interactive Political Communication.” *American Journal of Political Science* 66 (April 2022): 337–51.

Week 10

Tue, Nov 24 – **Ethics and Normative Concerns in Political Science.**

Readings:

- American Political Science Association. (2020). *A Guide to Professional Ethics in Political Science* (3rd ed.). Chapters 1-2.
- *Recommended:* Lupia, Arthur, and Colin Elman. “Openness in Political Science: Data Access and Research Transparency.” *PS: Political Science & Politics* 47 (Jan. 2014): 19–42.
- Soss, Joe, et al. “The Illusion of Technique: How Method-Driven Research Leads Welfare Scholarship Astray.” *Social Science Quarterly* 87 (Dec. 2006): 798–807 (assigned – reflection prompt on final exam).

Due: Third homework.

No class – Thu, Nov 26 (Thanksgiving break).

WCAS Reading Period – Nov 27 – Dec 4 (no classes).

Final exam: Friday, December 11, 2026, 12:00-2:00 PM (in class, open notes, closed devices)